

Euclid Book I: Reconstruction

Proposition I.5

In an Isosceles Triangle the Base Angles are Congruent

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1 Introduction

Proposition I.5 is the first theorem of Book I devoted specifically to the geometry of isosceles triangles. It establishes that the angles at the base of an isosceles triangle are congruent. Moreover, if the equal sides are extended beyond the base, the exterior angles formed by these extensions are also congruent.

In the Elements this proposition is one of the best known results of classical geometry and later became known under the traditional name *pons asinorum*. Although the theorem itself is elementary, it marks the beginning of a systematic study of congruence properties of triangles.

Euclid proves the proposition by combining the congruence theorem of Proposition I.4 with auxiliary constructions on the extensions of the equal sides.

In the present reconstruction the logical organization is different. The theorem is obtained by composing two previously established results of the Hilbert interface. The congruence of the base angles is provided by the theorem on isosceles triangles, while the congruence of the exterior angles follows from Hilbert's theorem on adjacent angles.

Consequently, Proposition I.5 is the first example in which a Euclidean proposition is reconstructed by combining several independent interface theorems rather than by introducing new geometric techniques.

2 The Classical Configuration

Euclid's proof of Proposition I.5 does not use only the original isosceles triangle and the extensions of its equal sides. It introduces additional auxiliary points and joins, producing a larger configuration to which Proposition I.4 can be applied.

Let ABC be an isosceles triangle satisfying

$$AB \cong AC.$$

Produce the equal sides AB and AC beyond the base vertices B and C . Euclid then chooses an auxiliary point on one extension, transfers a corresponding segment to the other extension, and joins the resulting points to the opposite vertices of the base.

The following sequence shows the successive stages of Euclid's configuration.

2.1 Initial Isosceles Triangle

The construction begins with an isosceles triangle ABC satisfying

$$AB \cong AC.$$

At this stage no auxiliary points or segments have yet been introduced.

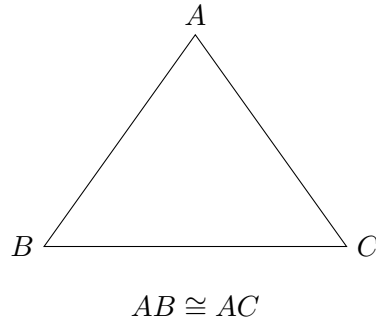


Figure 1: The initial isosceles triangle.

2.2 Extension of the Equal Sides

Euclid next produces the equal sides AB and AC beyond the base vertices. Let D lie beyond B on the line AB , and let E lie beyond C on the line AC .

Thus

$$A - B - D, \quad A - C - E.$$

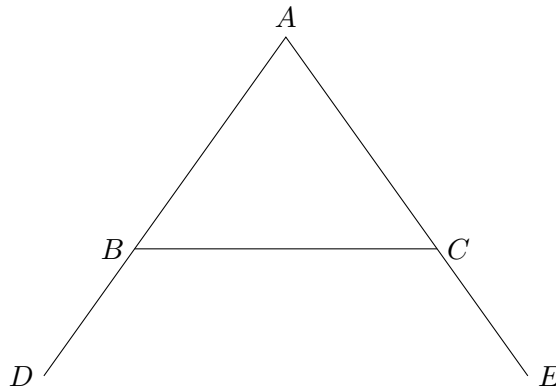


Figure 2: The equal sides AB and AC produced beyond B and C .

2.3 Choice of an Auxiliary Point

Euclid now chooses an arbitrary point F on the extension BD of the side AB .

Thus

$$A - B - F,$$

with F lying on the ray from A through B beyond the base vertex B .

2.4 Construction of an Equal Segment

Using Proposition I.3, Euclid marks a point G on the extension of AC such that

$$AG \cong AF.$$

The two auxiliary points are now related by the equality of the segments measured from the common vertex A .

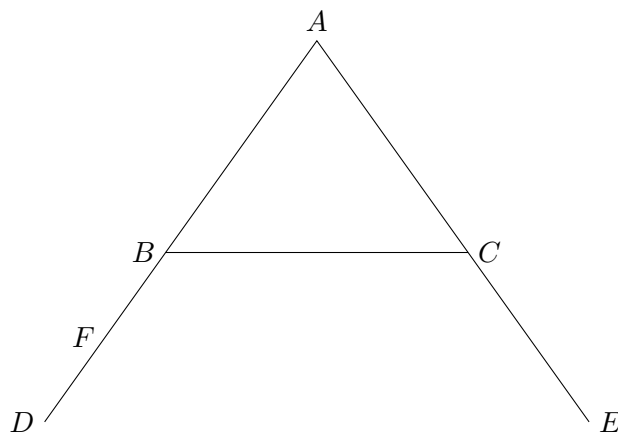


Figure 3: An arbitrary point F is chosen on the extension BD .

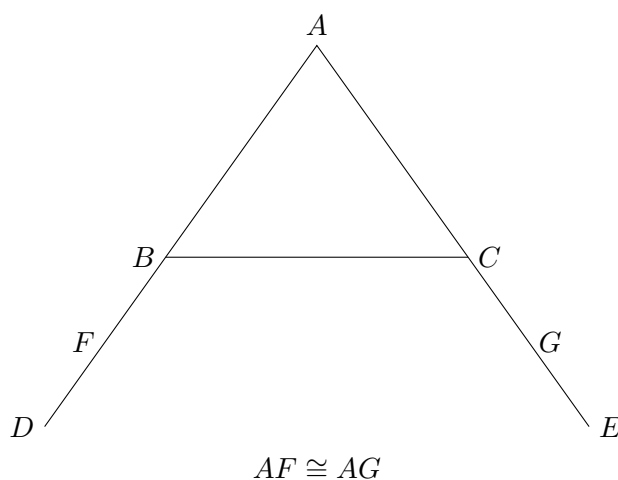


Figure 4: Construction of the equal segment $AG = AF$ using Proposition I.3.

2.5 Auxiliary Joins

The final step of Euclid's construction is to join the newly introduced points to the opposite vertices of the base.

The segments

$$FC \quad \text{and} \quad GB$$

complete the auxiliary configuration required for the proof.

3 Statement

Let ABC be a nondegenerate isosceles triangle satisfying

$$AB \cong AC.$$

Let the equal sides be extended beyond the base vertices so that

$$A - B - D, \quad A - C - E.$$

Then

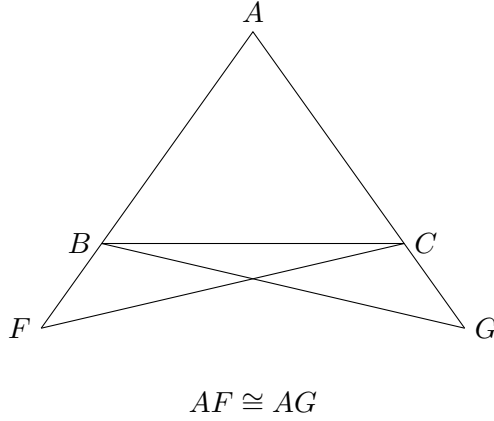


Figure 5: The complete auxiliary configuration used in Euclid's proof.

$$\angle ABC \cong \angle ACB,$$

and

$$\angle CBD \cong \angle BCE.$$

Thus both the base angles of the isosceles triangle and the exterior angles formed after extending the equal sides are congruent.

4 Proof

Euclid's proof is considerably more elaborate than the modern reconstruction presented later in this chapter. Rather than reasoning directly from the properties of an isosceles triangle, he introduces an auxiliary construction that allows repeated applications of the Side–Angle–Side congruence theorem established in Proposition I.4.

After extending the equal sides of the triangle, an arbitrary point is chosen on one extension. Proposition I.3 is then used to construct an equal segment on the opposite extension. The newly obtained points are joined to the opposite vertices of the base, completing the auxiliary configuration.

The proof proceeds by applying Proposition I.4 twice. The first application establishes congruence relations between the auxiliary triangles and yields equal corresponding sides and angles. These newly obtained equalities provide the hypotheses required for a second application of Proposition I.4.

Finally, Euclid combines the resulting congruence relations with the elementary properties of equal segments and equal angles to conclude that the interior base angles of the original isosceles triangle are congruent. The same argument immediately establishes the congruence of the corresponding exterior angles formed after extending the equal sides.

The auxiliary construction is therefore not an end in itself. Its sole purpose is to transform Proposition I.5 into two successive applications of Proposition I.4, allowing the theorem to be derived using only previously established geometric results.

5 Implementation Architecture

The formal proof of Proposition I.5 is obtained by composing two previously established theorems of the Hilbert interface.

The first theorem establishes the congruence of the base angles of an isosceles triangle. The second theorem transfers this congruence to the adjacent exterior angles after the equal sides have been extended.

The resulting logical dependency is shown below.

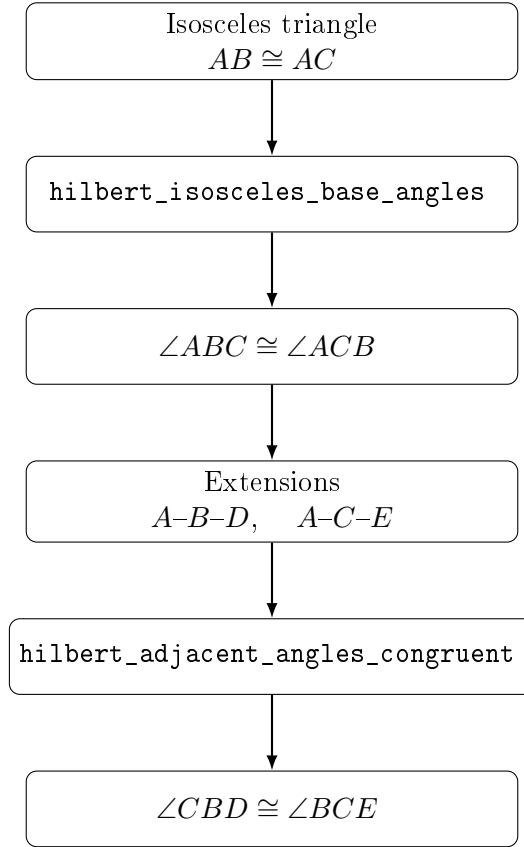


Figure 6: Implementation architecture of Proposition I.5.

Unlike the classical proof of Euclid, the formal development does not repeat the geometric argument establishing the base-angle theorem. Instead, the proposition is reconstructed by composing two independent results already available in the Hilbert interface. Consequently, Proposition I.5 illustrates the modular nature of the library: new Euclidean propositions are obtained by combining previously verified synthetic theorems.

6 Hilbert Reconstruction

The reconstruction of Proposition I.5 differs significantly from the classical proof presented in the *Elements*. Rather than repeating Euclid’s geometric argument, the result is obtained by combining two previously established theorems of the Hilbert interface.

The first theorem,

`hilbert_isosceles_base_angles,`

states that the base angles of a nondegenerate isosceles triangle are congruent. Applied to the hypothesis

$$AB \cong AC,$$

it immediately yields

$$\angle ABC \cong \angle ACB.$$

The second theorem,

`hilbert_adjacent_angles_congruent`,

uses the betweenness relations describing the extensions of the equal sides to transfer this congruence to the corresponding exterior angles.

Consequently,

$$\angle CBD \cong \angle BCE.$$

The reconstruction therefore introduces no new geometric machinery. Proposition I.5 is obtained entirely by composing two fundamental results already available in the Hilbert interface.

7 Lean Formalization

The Lean implementation follows the mathematical reconstruction directly.

The theorem first applies `hilbert_isosceles_base_angles` to obtain the congruence of the base angles of the isosceles triangle.

The resulting angle congruence is then supplied to `hilbert_adjacent_angles_congruent`, together with the two betweenness hypotheses describing the extensions of the equal sides.

The theorem therefore returns both conclusions of Proposition I.5:

$$\angle ABC \cong \angle ACB,$$

and

$$\angle CBD \cong \angle BCE.$$

Unlike Proposition I.4, whose formal proof consists of a single application of the SAS theorem, Proposition I.5 is the first Euclidean proposition reconstructed as a composition of multiple interface theorems.

8 Discussion

Proposition I.5 marks an important transition in the reconstruction of Book I.

The earlier propositions are centred on elementary constructions and a single application of the SAS theorem. Beginning with Proposition I.5, most subsequent propositions of Book I are expected to be reconstructed by composing previously established interface theorems.

This modular organization differs substantially from the presentation of the *Elements*. Euclid develops each proposition as an independent geometric argument, whereas the present reconstruction emphasizes reusable formal components. The resulting proofs are shorter, their logical dependencies are explicit, and each proposition becomes a thin verification layer built upon the synthetic theory already developed in the Hilbert interface.